

Checklist:

Engineering Culture

1. Opportunity and Membership

Define inclusion

- ☐ Ensure individuals have access to **opportunity** and **membership**.
- ☐ Treat **opportunity** as access to professional success and development.
- ☐ Treat **membership** as participation as a version of themselves they feel comfortable with.

Improve opportunity

- ☐ Create rubrics for important people decisions.
- ☐ Use rubrics for promotions, hiring, performance designations, management transitions, and similar decisions.
- ☐ Use structured processes to select project leads.
- ☐ Make education and conference budgets explicit.
- ☐ Reach out directly to people who may not apply for opportunities on their own.
- ☐ Create training and learning programs available to everyone.
- ☐ Respect the process even when it is inconvenient.
- ☐ Avoid concentrating opportunities among a small group of people.

Measure opportunity

- ☐ Track retention by cohort.
- ☐ Track usage rate: who is picked for project-selection opportunities.
- ☐ Track level distribution across different backgrounds.
- ☐ Track time at level before promotion.
- ☐ Review whether opportunities are distributed fairly.

Improve membership

- ☐ Create recurring weekly social events during working hours.
- ☐ Support Employee Resource Groups.

- ☐ Hold team offsites regularly.
- ☐ Use coffee chats to connect people across teams.
- ☐ Encourage team lunches, while being mindful of comfort and accessibility.
- ☐ Offer a portfolio of membership-building activities rather than relying on a single format.
- ☐ Avoid events that exclude people because of diet, physical ability, caregiving, timing, or comfort.

Measure membership

- ☐ Track retention as a long-term signal.
- ☐ Track referral rate by cohort.
- ☐ Track attendance at recurring events and team lunches.
- ☐ Track quantity and completion rate of coffee chats.
- ☐ Partner with HR to collect and interpret the data.

2. Select Project Leads Fairly

- ☐ Define the project's scope and goals in a short document.
- ☐ Specify the time commitment.
- ☐ Specify requirements to apply, or explicitly state there are none.
- ☐ Specify clear selection criteria.
- ☐ Announce the opportunity broadly.
- ☐ Allow people to apply privately.
- ☐ Do not show applicants who else has applied.
- ☐ Give people at least three working days to apply.
- ☐ Personally nudge strong candidates who may not self-select.
- ☐ Select the project lead based on the stated criteria.
- ☐ Consider every applicant against the criteria.
- ☐ Write a short rationale for each applicant where possible.
- ☐ Privately confirm with the selected lead.
- ☐ Assign a sponsor who has successfully completed a similar project.
- ☐ Notify applicants who were not selected.
- ☐ Give helpful feedback to rejected applicants.
- ☐ Kick off the project with the lead, sponsor, and relevant stakeholders.
- ☐ Record the project, selected lead, sponsor, and project brief in a public spreadsheet.
- ☐ Track who gets leaned on for important work over time.

3. Make Your Peers Your First Team

- ☐ Learn what your peers are working on.
- ☐ Invest time in understanding peer goals, constraints, and priorities.
- ☐ Spend time together so peers become people, not abstract roles.
- ☐ Avoid projecting motives onto peers you do not know well.
- ☐ Create conditions where peers help one another succeed.
- ☐ Avoid zero-sum culture around scarce rewards.
- ☐ Explicitly discuss shifting identity from “my team only” to “my peer team first.”
- ☐ Treat peer collaboration as a core part of management work.
- ☐ Join a rapidly expanding company where peer learning is abundant, when possible.
- ☐ Make your peers your first team.

4. Build Inclusive Senior-Role Processes

- ☐ Announce senior roles internally.
- ☐ Ask for internal candidates.
- ☐ Encourage eligible people to apply, especially those who are uncertain.
- ☐ Give candidates a week or two to consider applying.
- ☐ Ensure every internal candidate has a structured way to apply.
- ☐ Evaluate candidates fairly; do not default to preferring internal candidates.

Evaluate candidates on:

- ☐ Partnership with peers and managed teams.
- ☐ Execution and operational excellence.
- ☐ Vision for the team's future.
- ☐ Strategy to move from current state to future state.
- ☐ Spoken and written communication.
- ☐ Stakeholder management.

Use structured assessment tools

- ☐ Collect feedback from four or five coworkers.
- ☐ Include peers from other teams.
- ☐ Include people the candidate has managed.

- ☐ Include people the candidate would not manage.
- ☐ Ask candidates to write a 90-day transition plan.
- ☐ Provide feedback on the 90-day plan.
- ☐ Ask candidates to write a vision/strategy document.
- ☐ Provide feedback on the strategy document.
- ☐ Have candidates present their strategy to peers.
- ☐ Have candidates present one-on-one to an executive.
- ☐ Use the process as practice and development, not only evaluation.

5. Manage Company Freedoms Deliberately

- ☐ Identify the positive freedoms your culture enables.
- ☐ Identify the negative freedoms your culture protects against.
- ☐ Recognize that every positive freedom can reduce a negative freedom.
- ☐ Recognize that every negative freedom can eliminate a positive freedom.
- ☐ Balance freedom with consequence.
- ☐ Avoid treating freedom as an excuse for not taking accountability.
- ☐ Use systems thinking to understand cultural freedoms.
- ☐ Keep processes that are working.
- ☐ Change processes when they no longer fit new projects or circumstances.
- ☐ Avoid blindly importing cultural practices from companies in different contexts.
- ☐ Place positive and negative freedoms in the right circumstances.

6. Kill Your Heroes, Stop Doing It Harder

Watch for hero culture

- ☐ Notice when “work harder” becomes the default answer.
- ☐ Recognize that heroic work often prevents nonheroes from contributing.
- ☐ Watch for burned-out heroes.
- ☐ Watch for alienated teammates.
- ☐ Watch for projects that remain broken despite heroic effort.
- ☐ Do not reward systems that depend on one or two exceptional people.

Reset broken systems

- ☐ Identify whether the problem is an effort issue or a system design issue.

- ☐ Look for stockpiles of accumulated problems rather than single causes.
- ☐ Accept that projects fail one sprint at a time.
- ☐ Accept that fixing projects also takes time.
- ☐ Stop using short bursts of effort to cover months of bad process.
- ☐ Reset direction when you have the authority to do so.
- ☐ Take responsibility when you set the original direction.
- ☐ Cut losses quickly when decisions were wrong.
- ☐ Help the team reach a reset point when you do not control policy.
- ☐ Step back from broken systems that absorb effort without improving.
- ☐ Avoid creating rifts by pushing others into hero mode.
- ☐ Learn from mistakes and move forward.